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ProductBeacon – State of Workforce Engagement Management 2026: The Autonomous CX Market

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Former-employer independence: The author was employed by NICE (9 April 2008 to 20 May 2021), holding senior product-leadership responsibility for the Recording / Workforce-Optimization line of business – the very domain this report grades NICE on – and remains bound by a confidentiality and trade-secret undertaking from that employment; this report relies solely on published material and contains no information derived from that employment, and the author holds no NICE equity.

5.1 What This Market Is

What this market is. Autonomous CX is software where an **AI agent resolves the customer's issue end-to-end with no human in the loop**. It is self-service that *acts*: it executes the refund, processes the claim, and navigates back-office systems to close the case. It does more than answer. It is the other side of the **control-surface line** from Agent-Assist: where Agent-Assist guides a human who acts, Autonomous CX *is* the action. This is the market that physically **resets the seat count** the rest of WFO is priced against. When the agent stops being a human, the unit being staffed, scheduled, scored, and coached changes.

The buyer is the deflected interaction. In practice the buyer is the CX/automation leader buying autonomous resolution, and the thing being bought is the share of contacts that never reach a human at all.

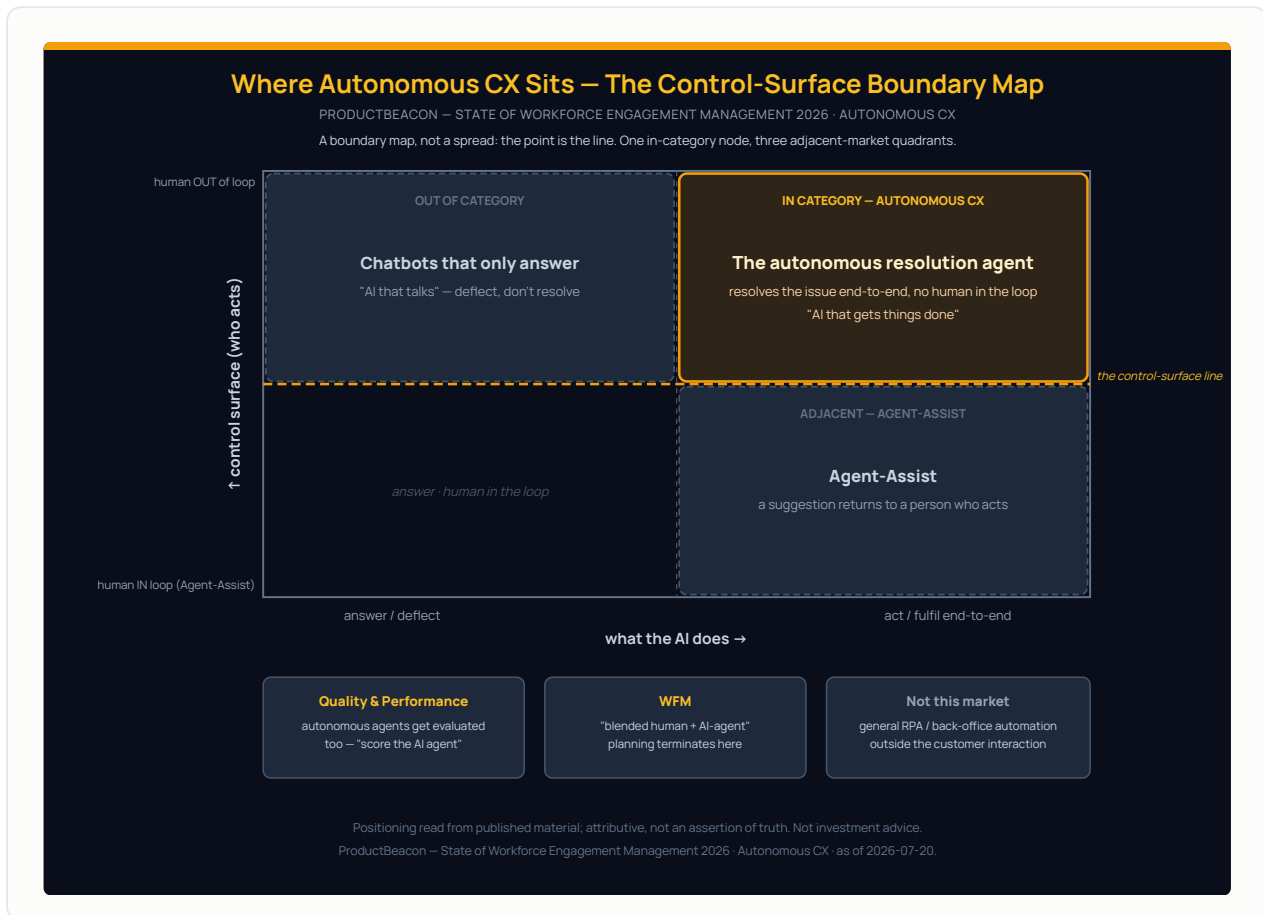
Where the boundaries fall.

- **vs Agent-Assist – the control-surface line:** assist returns a suggestion to a person; autonomous performs the resolving action. **Same engine, two SKUs, gated by who acts**, which is why the assist vendor and the autonomous vendor are usually the same vendor (NICE Copilot/Autopilot; Cresta Agent Assist/AI Agent).
- **vs QM / Performance:** autonomous agents get *evaluated* too – “score the AI agent” pulls quality and performance management onto this market (Sprinklr “Autonomous Evaluation”).
- **vs WFM:** the thing being scheduled stops being only human. WFM's “blended human + AI-agent” planning (Workforce Management Pattern Claim 3) terminates here.

What it IS NOT. Not assist (Agent-Assist – the human still acts). Not chatbots that only *answer* (the “AI that talks” vs “AI that gets things done” line the vendors themselves draw). Not general RPA / back-office automation outside the customer interaction.

Three common buyer misconceptions. 1. “Autonomous CX is just a better chatbot.” A chatbot answers; an autonomous agent *acts*: it executes a 40-step refund flow, triggers fulfillment, and works across systems. The dividing line is execution, not eloquence. 2. “Deflection rate is the metric.” It is becoming **fulfillment rate**: the share of interactions the agent *resolves end-to-end*, instead of merely keeping them away from a human. 3. “The frontier valuations mean autonomous has already won.” The seat-reset is **observable in pricing today** (per-resolution), but the *displacement* is a forecast – and a contested

one. Gartner's "80% autonomous by 2029" pull sits against its own counter-signal that a large share of agentic projects get canceled. Price migration is fact; seat elimination is a bet (see the Winning & Losing section).



Where Autonomous CX sits: a boundary map on the control-surface line. One in-category node (the autonomous resolution agent), with the adjacent markets at the edges.

5.2 Market Size & Trends

Category-scoping note. Sized as **autonomous AI agents that resolve customer interactions with no human in the loop** (voice + digital). **In scope:** the autonomous resolution agent. **Out of scope:** real-time assist to a human (Agent-Assist, the control-surface line), and the inflated horizontal "AI agents / agentic AI" market numbers (43–46% CAGRs, hundreds of billions)³. We report those horizontal numbers separately and do not add them into a CX-autonomy TAM. There is no clean standalone autonomous-CX

dollar TAM. The nearest CX-scoped market is AI-for-customer-service (~\$12B/2024 → ~\$48B/2030 at ~25.8%, MarketsandMarkets¹; CAGR corroborated by Grand View / Mordor conversational-AI ~23–24%²), reported as the wider category, not the autonomous-CX number.

The seat-reset is a direction (P3), not a market size. Public deflection/resolution signals point one way but carry their own caveat. Klarna publicly claimed its AI assistant did the work of ~700 agents / two-thirds of chats – and then, per CEO Sebastian Siemiatkowski's 2025 public statements, *partly reversea course* and moved to re-add human support, the single most important counter-datapoint⁴⁵. Salesforce cites Agentforce resolving ~84% of its own support (~380K conversations)⁶. Both are reported as labeled, dated vendor/named-outlet claims. In-window coverage (July 2026) enriches both sides of the Klarna datapoint without resolving it: Forbes reports the assistant's workload has grown to the equivalent of ~850 agents (16 Jul 2026), while the re-added human support is reported as gig-structured – “an Uber type of set-up,” per CEO Siemiatkowski (The Guardian, 18 Jun 2026). Both at named-outlet attribution; neither a new reversal nor a retraction.

The central finding: per-resolution pricing is published today (P2). This market is where per-seat licensing visibly breaks. Unlike the seat-displacement *forecast*, the pricing migration is **reader-checkable right now** on dated public pages:

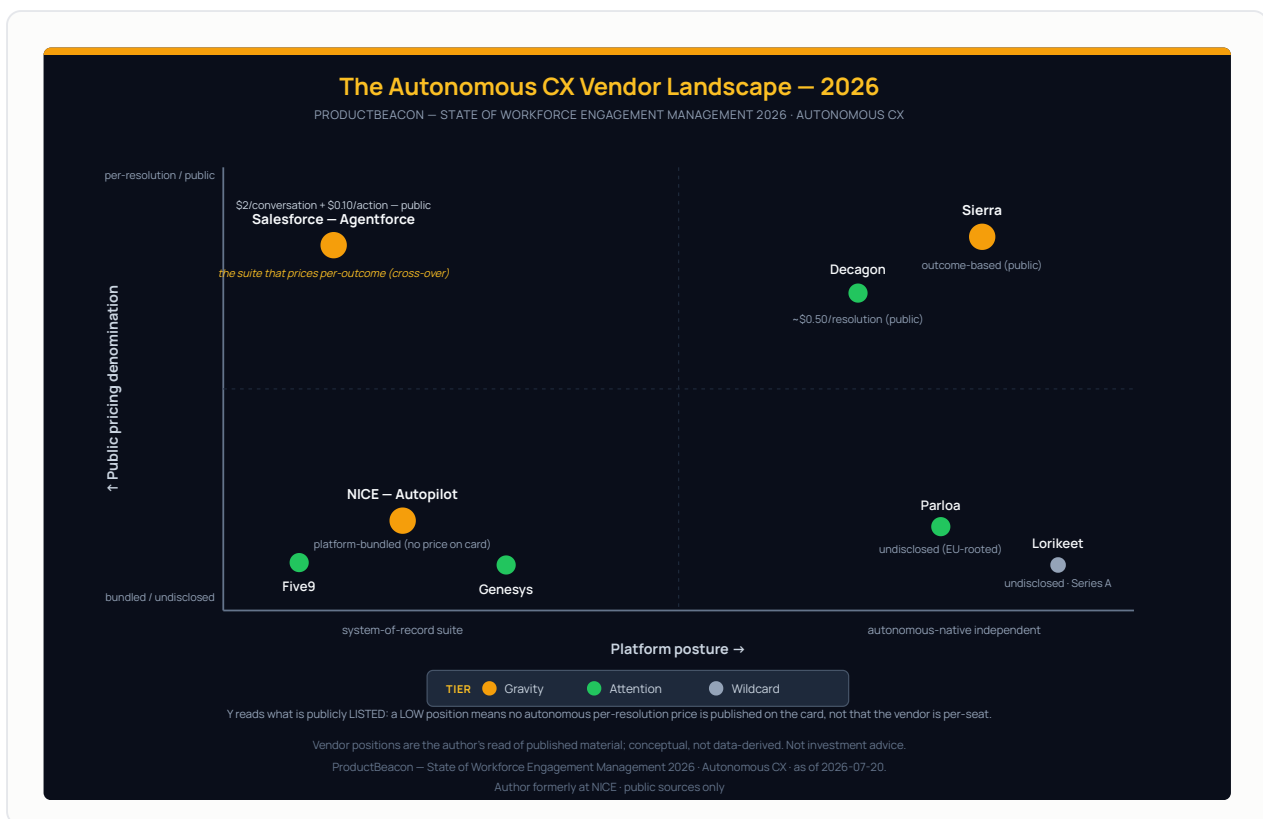
- **Sierra:** outcome-based (“pay on successful resolution”)⁷.
- **Salesforce Agentforce \$2/conversation + \$0.10/action** (Flex Credits)⁸.
- **Fin (formerly Intercom) \$0.99/outcome**⁹. Its acquisition by Salesforce was announced 15 Jun 2026 (~\$3.6B, close expected Salesforce fiscal Q4 2027).
- **Decagon ~\$0.50/resolution**, on a \$50K platform fee.¹⁰ **Decagon's price** is reported, not published: the company has no public pricing page.
- **Zendesk per automated resolution** (the construct is printed on its pricing page; the \$1.50–2.00 range as previously reported)¹¹.
- **Gorgias ~\$0.60–1.27/resolution**¹¹.

On 25 June 2026, after the research cut, **Salesforce announced pay-per-resolution** for its Agentforce Help Agent, “charged when Help Agent resolves an issue autonomously, start to finish” (salesforce.com; GA July 2026). The \$2 price point is reported by CIO and was not yet printed on the pricing page as of 20 July 2026. The result is a coherent pricing layer denominated in *resolutions*, not seats. We re-verified every anchor page above live on 20 July 2026: **none withdrawn, none reverted**. This is the cleanest public proof the Convergence P2 thesis survives its first test. *Sizing confidence is moderate: no clean TAM exists, and that is reported as a gap. P2-pricing confidence is high.*

Compliance. Human-out-of-the-loop resolution sharpens the liability profile. The **EU AI Act deployer bears liability** for an autonomous agent's actions¹², with full application in August 2026¹³. The agent-governance gap is already a procurement blocker¹⁴.

5.3 The Contenders

Eight vendors are graded on the 3-bucket rubric (cap 8). The three tiers group vendors by market weight: **Gravity** is the largest incumbents that pull the market, **Attention** is the credible mid-players worth watching, and **Wildcard** is the challenger or thin, early entrant. Each card carries a verbatim vendor pillar + inline dated URL. **The viability bright line is the key discipline here:** funding raises are reported as primary-source fact; viability verdicts on pre-Series-B privates are withheld. AI-architecture verbs are publicly-evidenced positioning.



The Autonomous CX vendor landscape: platform posture (suite vs autonomous-native) against public pricing denomination. Salesforce is the suite cross-over that prices per-outcome.

Gravity tier

1. Salesforce: Agentforce. The market's gravitational center (NYSE: CRM). GA (29 Oct 2024): the pitch is “Trusted, Autonomous AI Agents...” built on the **Atlas Reasoning Engine** (salesforce.com)¹⁵. Salesforce positions them as going “beyond chatbots and copilots, using advanced reasoning abilities to make decisions and take action, like resolving customer cases,” per the launch release. The same release describes an agent that “doesn’t depend on human engagement to get work done,” in its own words. *Pricing (a flagship P2 anchor, public): \$2/conversation, then \$0.10/action* (Flex Credits, May 2025)¹⁶, plus per-user add-ons, three coexisting publicly-listed models, plus a fourth, pay-per-resolution for Help Agent, announced 25 Jun 2026 (see Market Size & Trends). *Scale (vendor-reported, attributed):*

Salesforce reports Agentforce at “\$1.2 billion in ARR in Q1 FY27, up 205% year-over-year” (salesforce.com release 15 Jun 2026, originating in its 27 May 2026 Q1 FY27 results). It is native autonomous CX on the system of record.

2. NICE: CXone Mpower Autopilot + Mpower Agents. The customer-facing twin of the same Enlighten spine graded across all four preceding markets. **Mpower Agents** (17 Jun 2025): “**fully automated, AI agents... created and deployed in seconds**” that “**automate complete journeys, not just conversations**”. They also “**actively move across systems, trigger actions,**” with the category line “**AI that gets things done**” vs “**AI that talks**” (nice.com)¹⁷. **Cognigy** (acquired 8 Sep 2025, ~\$955M)¹⁸ is the agentic capability *inside* this card. **The single-engine proof:** NICE positions Mpower agents to “support employees via **Mpower Copilot** or serve customers directly via **Mpower Autopilot**, tapping into the full CXone Mpower ecosystem.”¹⁹ That is *one platform, two SKUs, gated by who acts*: the P1 proxy made physical. In a 9 Jun 2026 platform announcement, NICE re-architected the story around the acquired asset: “agentic AI native at the core of its platform,” with NICE Cognigy as the brain and three named layers: NICE AI Agents, Agentic Engagement Plane, Agentic Analytics (nice.com, 9 Jun 2026). The spanning-engine narrative now centers Cognigy alongside Enlighten: the platform story deepens while the engine NAME migrates. It is a Convergence P1 proxy.

3. Sierra: AI agents for CX (autonomous-native, post-Series-E). The most heavily-valued independent (co-founded by ex-Salesforce co-CEO Bret Taylor): “**Better customer experiences. Built on Sierra,**” one agent across “chat, SMS, WhatsApp, email, voice, and ChatGPT” (sierra.ai)²⁰. *The P2 signature:* “**only pay for the value Sierra delivers with outcome-based pricing,**” billed “**when the AI agent achieves a successful resolution**” with no charge on escalation (sierra.ai)²¹. *Funding (primary-source):* Series C \$350M at ~\$10B (4 Sep 2025); **Series E \$950M at ~\$15.8B (4 May 2026, GV + Tiger Global).**²² *Sierra is post-Series-E, so the viability restriction does not apply.* On 16 July 2026, after the research cut, Sierra extended the model with **Horizon** agents that orchestrate interactions “over days or weeks,” on the same outcomes basis (sierra.ai). The pricing line is unchanged: “you pay for results, not tokens”. TechCrunch reports ~\$200M ARR per a CEO announcement (8 Jul 2026, reported, not primary). The outcome-pricing page was re-verified intact on 20 July 2026.

Attention tier

4. Genesys: Agentic Virtual Agent (suite-native). “**Go beyond responses to real customer outcomes,**” agents that “**reason, plan and execute complete workflows across systems,**” and the blunt line “**Conversations don’t resolve customer issues: execution**”. Its 9 Sep 2025 launch claims “**the industry’s first agentic virtual agent built with large action models (LAMs)**” with A2A + MCP support (genesys.com)²³. On 30 June 2026, after the research cut, Genesys acquired **Pinkfish**, an agentic-orchestration workflow company, expanding Agentic Virtual Agent with MCP-based tool integration and workflow automation (genesys.com; terms undisclosed). It is a P1 proxy. *Funding note: Genesys’s press-estimated \$15–21B valuation is not carried on the card; the confirmed \$1.5B Salesforce+ServiceNow event was a share-repurchase strategic investment with no post-money.*²⁴

5. Five9: AI Agents / Agentic CX (NASDAQ: FIVN). Launch (10 Jun 2025): “**AI Agents that can Reason, Decide, and Take Action,**” “**built on the Agentic Experience Engine,**” paired with an explicit **AI trust & governance** layer (five9.com)²⁵. The “**Agentic Experience Engine**”, one named engine powering both Agent Assist and the autonomous AI Agents, is the strongest single-engine-named evidence in the

report. *Freshness note (20 Jul 2026): the Agentic Experience Engine name remains present across Five9's public surfaces as observed this cycle: the launch release ("draw on the Five9 Agentic Experience Engine"), current blog and Genius AI resource pages, and localized product pages. So Five9 counts in the P1 tally as-is. The observed drift is de-emphasis, not fragmentation. The mid-2026 EN product page and the 23 Jun 2026 Voice AI Agents release ("a completely new, purpose-built architecture") keep the name out of primary copy. That is a watch item; the human-oversight gate persists per launch coverage. It is a P1 proxy.*

6. Decagon: AI concierge (autonomous-native, post-Series-D). **"The AI concierge for every customer,"** resolving end-to-end across "voice, chat, and email" with **"cross-channel memory"** on a **"Build once. Deploy everywhere"** model, with a vendor-claimed 70%+ resolution rate (decagon.ai)²⁶. *Funding (primary-source): Series C \$131M at ~\$1.5B (23 Jun 2025); Series D \$250M at ~\$4.5B (28 Jan 2026, Coatue + Index)*²⁷. *The \$1.5B is the older round; the current mark is \$4.5B.* Decagon is post-Series-D, so the viability restriction does not apply. In June 2026, after the research cut, Decagon launched **Duet Autopilot** and an operator-led positioning push around Agent Operating Procedures (decagon.ai), with no funding delta.

7. Parloa: Agentic AI (autonomous-native, post-Series-D, EU-rooted). The **AI Agent Management Platform**, framed **"Reinvent Customer Service with Agentic AI,"** voice-first at enterprise scale (BusinessWire)²⁸. *Funding (primary-source): Series C \$120M at ~\$1B (6 May 2025); Series D \$350M at ~\$3B (15 Jan 2026, General Catalyst) – valuation "tripled in ~8 months" (TechCrunch).*²⁹ Post-Series-D → no viability restriction. On 17 June 2026, after the research cut, Parloa announced a strategic partnership with Alvaria, calling itself "the first and only agentic AI provider to integrate with the Alvaria Intelligence Platform" (PRNewswire): an autonomous-native vendor tying up with a heritage outbound platform. *(The partner is the Alvaria outbound/compliance platform, not the Aspect WFM line – this is not a WFM event.)*

Wildcard tier

8. Lorikeet: AI Customer Concierge (the genuine viability hard-case, Series A). **"The AI Customer Concierge for complex companies,"** with the wedge **"Where other agents deflect, Lorikeet leans in, handling high-stakes problems with precision": "whether it's a three-step form or a 40-step refund flow, Lorikeet executes with precision."** The positioning pairs honest escalation with a compliance frame (lorikeetcx.ai)³⁰. *Funding (primary-source): Series A \$35M (~Aug 2025, QED Investors), preceded by \$5M seed (Oct 2024) + \$9M extension (Feb 2025).*³¹ **Held to strategy opinion only at this Series-A funding stage: funding reported as fact; NO viability/displacement/distress claim.** *(Named-outlet "~\$75M total / val >\$200M" carried as a claim, not audited fact.)*

Cross-market bookkeeping: Cresta's AI Agent is a Play here (Cresta is a two-card vendor, Quality + Agent-Assist); Observe.AI's VoiceAI is a Play (Quality is its primary card); Sprinklr's Autonomous Evaluation is a Play (recorded once in the cross-market ledger, not double-listed). Cognigy sits inside NICE; Thoma Bravo CX appears only as a Play via Cogito (not covered here). The viability bright line held for the alternates too: Wonderful (\$100M Series A)³², Crescendo (\$50M/~\$500M)³³, Gradient Labs (\$26M Series A): all funding as fact, viability silent.

5.4 What the Vendors Are Doing

Play 1: Two engines – the system-of-record suite vs the autonomous-native independent

Suites sell autonomous CX as a native module on the platform you already run (Agentforce, NICE Mpower Agents, Genesys, Five9). The natives sell the agent as the whole product (Sierra, Decagon, Parloa, Lorikeet). The market's central falsification condition: does "it's already on your platform" beat "we resolve harder, end-to-end, priced per outcome." *Feeds Convergence P1*.

Play 2: Per-resolution / outcome pricing becomes the market's economic signature

Sierra outcome-based; Salesforce \$2/conversation + \$0.10/action; Decagon ~\$0.50; Intercom Fin \$0.99: the cleanest public **vendor-pricing-disclosure** evidence for P2, reported as pricing disclosure, *never* a seat-count forecast.

Play 3: "Reason + act across systems" replaces "answer the question" – deflection becomes fulfillment

NICE "AI that gets things done"; Genesys "goal attainment" over "intent matching"; Salesforce Atlas; Five9 "reason, decide, act." The buyer's metric becomes *fulfillment rate*, not deflection rate.

Play 4: The assist engine becomes the autonomous engine – the two-market pull from Agent-Assist completes here

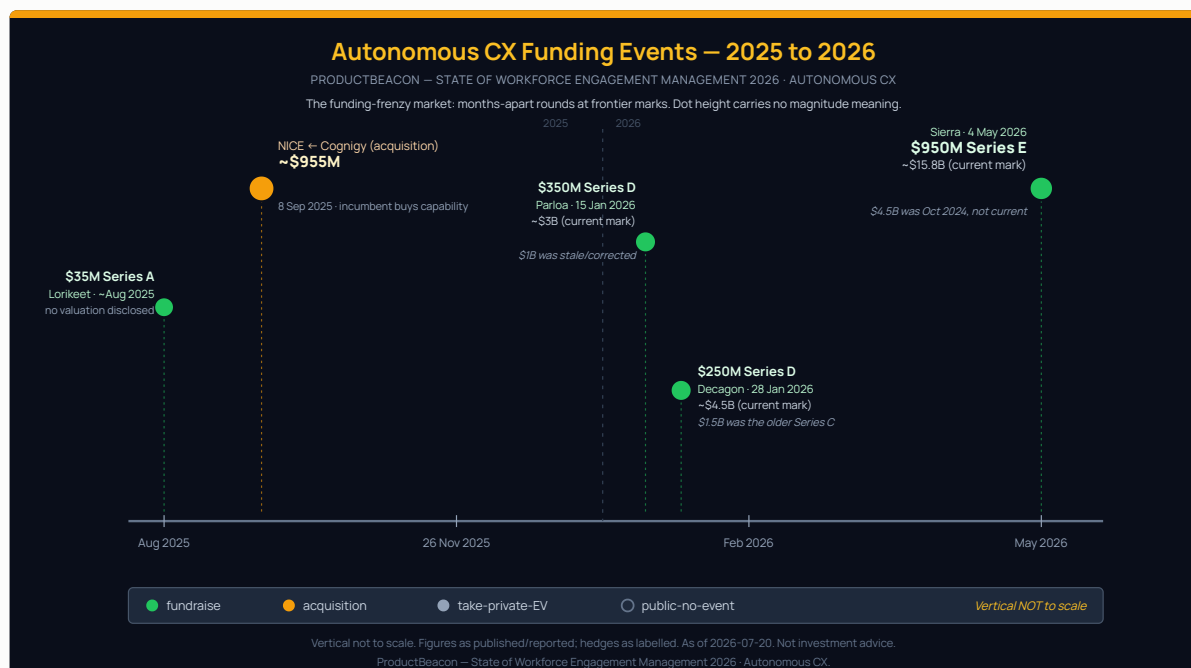
Cresta AI Agent³⁴; Observe.AI VoiceAI³⁵; Balto Togo. The per-seat→per-outcome migration begins exactly where the engine that *guided* the human starts *replacing* the human.

Play 5: Trust, governance, and evaluation become the autonomous-CX procurement gate

Five9 trust & governance; Genesys guardrails + A2A/MCP; Salesforce "Trusted"; Sprinklr "Autonomous Evaluation."³⁶ The same evaluation lens that validates a copilot validates an autonomous agent.

5.5 Funding & Fault-Lines

Vendor	Round / status	Valuation	Investor
Salesforce	Public (NYSE: CRM)	Public equity	—
NICE	Public (NASDAQ/TASE); Cognigy ~\$955M (8 Sep 2025) ³⁷	Public equity	acquirer
Sierra	Series E \$950M (4 May 2026) ³⁸	~\$15.8B	GV, Tiger Global
Genesys	Private (Permira/H&F); \$1.5B Salesforce+ServiceNow <i>share-repurchase</i> (no post-money) ³⁹	not carried (press-estimate \$15–21B unconfirmed)	—
Five9	Public (NASDAQ: FIVN)	Public equity	—
Decagon	Series D \$250M (28 Jan 2026) ⁴⁰	~\$4.5B	Coatue, Index
Parloa	Series D \$350M (15 Jan 2026) ⁴¹	~\$3B	General Catalyst
Lorikeet (Wildcard)	Series A \$35M (~Aug 2025) ⁴²	not disclosed (no viability claim)	QED



Autonomous CX funding events, 2025 to 2026: months-apart rounds at frontier marks alongside the NICE-Cognigy acquisition. Vertical not to scale.

The funding-frenzy market. The autonomous-native independents are raising at frontier valuations on months-apart rounds: Sierra ~\$15.8B, Decagon ~\$4.5B, Parloa ~\$3B, each re-priced within ~7–8 months. The incumbents *build or buy* (NICE→Cognigy ~\$955M) rather than out-raise. The structural read: autonomous CX is the one WEM market where independent capital is genuinely competing with the suites for the category, not just the feature.

Fault-lines (disclosed, not guessed; figures re-verified at primary source). Multiple valuations in the report's working brief were **stale and corrected**: Decagon's current mark is \$4.5B, not \$1.5B (that was the older Series C); Parloa is \$3B, not \$1B; Sierra's \$4.5B was Oct 2024, not current. **Genesys's \$15–21B is press-estimate-only and is NOT carried here**: the confirmed event was a share-repurchase strategic investment with no post-money. **Lorikeet has no disclosed valuation** at any round (none asserted). No distress/viability claim on any private (strategy opinion only, absent a primary-source event).

5.6 Winning & Losing

These are my read of where this market is heading – each anchored to public evidence already cited above, framed as opinion, and stated as a falsifiable prediction with a dated checkpoint.

Pattern Claim 1 – The Seat-Reset Is Priced, Not Forecast

Observation. Autonomous-CX vendors publicly list pricing denominated in *resolutions*, not seats, on dated pages today: Sierra outcome-based (“pay on successful resolution”)⁷, Salesforce Agentforce \$2/conversation + \$0.10/action⁸, Fin (formerly Intercom) \$0.99/outcome⁹. Decagon is at ~\$0.50 (reported)¹⁰, and Zendesk prices per automated resolution (vendor pages / named-outlet, 2026-06-16; anchor pages re-verified 2026-07-20: none withdrawn or reverted)¹¹. **My read.** The per-seat→per-outcome migration the Convergence chapter tracks is *observable in pricing now* – a published, reader-checkable fact, distinct from the *seat-displacement forecast* (which is contested). The economic unit of CX is moving from the seat to the resolved interaction. The vendors have already re-denominated their price lists to match. This is the strongest single piece of public evidence for the report's central bet. **Conditional prediction.** If by **H1 2027** at least **2** Gravity-tier vendors price a flagship customer-facing CX-agent SKU primarily off per-seat (to per-resolution / per-conversation / per-action) on a dated public page, the pricing migration is confirmed. If the flagship SKUs revert to or stay per-seat, the seat-reset is a marketing frame, not an economic one. (*Watch the single most important counter-signal: any vendor publicly reverting off per-resolution back to per-seat.*) **Sources.** The Market Size & Trends section's published per-resolution price lists (Sierra, Agentforce, Intercom Fin, Decagon, Zendesk; vendor pages / named outlets, accessed 2026-06-16) and Play 2 above.

Claim 1 — The seat-reset is priced, not forecast

Per-resolution price lists are public, dated, and reader-checkable today.

Sierra	outcome-based — pay on successful resolution
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Salesforce Agentforce	\$2 / conversation + \$0.10 / action
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Intercom Fin	\$0.99 / resolution
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Decagon	~\$0.50 / resolution (+ platform fee)
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Zendesk	\$1.50–2.00 / automated resolution
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the unit of value: SEAT → RESOLVED INTERACTION (pricing = fact)

Counter-signal to watch: any Gravity vendor reverting off per-resolution back to per-seat.

FALSIFIABLE TEST — checkpoint H1 2027

CONFIRMED if at least 2 Gravity-tier vendors price a flagship customer-facing CX-agent SKU off per-resolution / per-conversation / per-action on a dated public page.

FALSIFIED if the flagship SKUs revert to or stay per-seat — the seat-reset is a marketing frame, not an economic one.

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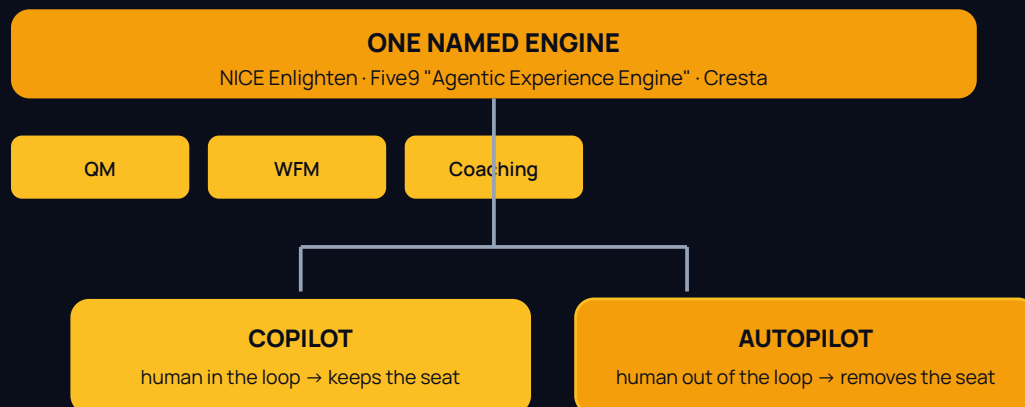
Claim 1 — the seat-reset is priced, not forecast: per-resolution price lists are public, dated, and reader-checkable today.

Pattern Claim 2 – One Engine, Gated by Who Acts

Observation. The suites position autonomous CX as the customer-facing SKU of the *same* engine that powers their assist SKU. NICE's Mpower agents "support employees via Mpower **Copilot** or serve customers directly via Mpower **Autopilot**, tapping into the full CXone Mpower ecosystem."¹⁹ Five9's autonomous AI Agents and Agent Assist both run on one named "**Agentic Experience Engine**"²⁵. Cresta pairs Agent Assist with AI Agent on one platform (dated vendor pages, 2026-06-16)³⁴. **My read.** The single-engine P1 thesis is *made physical* at the control-surface gate: one engine, exposed as assist or autonomous depending only on whether a human is in the loop. The suite's advantage is that the autonomous SKU is a configuration of the engine the buyer already runs for QM/WFM/coaching/assist. That is exactly the single-engine-collapse claim, now visible as a SKU boundary rather than an architecture diagram. **Conditional prediction.** If by **Q4 2026** at least **3** Gravity-tier vendors publicly name one platform/engine spanning assist *and* autonomous (a Copilot/Autopilot-style paired SKU on one ecosystem), the single-engine collapse is confirmed at the product surface. If assist and autonomous remain separately-branded, separately-architected products, the collapse is weaker than the marketing implies. **Sources.** The NICE Mpower Copilot/Autopilot and Five9 "Agentic Experience Engine" copy quoted in the Contenders section (accessed 2026-06-16) and Play 1 above.

Claim 2 – One engine, gated by who acts

The autonomous SKU is a configuration of the engine the buyer already runs.



NICE's own copy: Mpower agents serve via Copilot OR Autopilot, "tapping the full CXone Mpower ecosystem." Checkpoint Q4 2026: ≥3 vendors.

FALSIFIABLE TEST – checkpoint Q4 2026

CONFIRMED if at least 3 Gravity-tier vendors publicly name one platform / engine spanning assist and autonomous (a Copilot / Autopilot-style paired SKU on one ecosystem).

FALSIFIED if assist and autonomous stay separately-branded, separately-architected products – the collapse is weaker than the marketing implies.

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Claim 2 – one engine, gated by who acts: the autonomous SKU is a configuration of the engine the buyer already runs.

Pattern Claim 3 – Fulfillment, Not Deflection, and the Contested Displacement

Observation. Vendors are redefining the metric from *deflection* (keep it from a human) to *fulfillment* (the agent executes the resolution end-to-end: NICE “AI that gets things done,”¹⁷ Genesys “execution,”²³ Lorikeet “40-step refund flow”³⁰). Meanwhile the displacement evidence is genuinely two-sided (Salesforce ~84% self-resolution⁶ vs Klarna’s public partial *reversal* of its agent-replacement claim⁵; Gartner’s 80%-by-2029⁴³ vs its ~40%-of-agentic-projects-canceled-by-2027⁴⁴). **My read.** The category’s *capability* claim (fulfillment, not deflection) is advancing fast and is the right buyer metric. The *displacement* claim (autonomous removes the human seat at scale) is contested and is the report’s real falsification condition. Price migration is fact, fulfillment is rising, but seat elimination at scale is a bet with a live counter-signal. **Conditional prediction.** If by **mid-2027** named enterprises publicly report *sustained* (not pilot-only) autonomous fulfillment rates above 50% on a primary channel **without a Klarna-style reversal**, the displacement thesis strengthens. If the public reversals/cancellations outweigh the sustained-fulfillment disclosures, the seat-reset stays a pricing phenomenon ahead of a staffing one. **Sources.** The Market Size & Trends section’s deflection and counter-signal evidence (Salesforce ~84% self-resolution; the Klarna counter-signal; Gartner’s 80%-by-2029 vs its cancellation projection) and Play 3 above.

Claim 3 — Fulfillment, not deflection

The metric shifts; the displacement stays a genuinely two-sided bet.



Honest position: pricing = fact · fulfillment = rising · seat elimination = the bet.

Checkpoint mid-2027: sustained (non-pilot) fulfillment above 50% on a primary channel, no Klarna-style reversal.

FALSIFIABLE TEST — checkpoint mid-2027

DISPLACEMENT STRENGTHENS if named enterprises publicly report sustained (not pilot-only) autonomous fulfillment above 50% on a primary channel, no Klarna-style reversal.

STAYS PRICING-ONLY if public reversals / cancellations outweigh sustained-fulfillment disclosures — the seat-reset stays a pricing phenomenon ahead of a staffing one.

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Claim 3 — fulfillment, not deflection: the metric shifts while seat-displacement stays a genuinely two-sided bet.

Winners

These verdicts translate the tier placements and plays above. They are my opinion, not a scoreboard. **Salesforce.** Agentforce is native autonomous CX on the system of record, with per-conversation and per-action pricing already public¹⁶ (its Gravity-tier card above). **NICE.** Autonomous on the WEM incumbent: Mpower Autopilot is the customer-facing SKU of the same Enlighten spine graded across all four preceding markets, with Cognigy (~\$955M)¹⁸ bought in as the agentic capability. The system-of-record pull is the strongest position in this market: the autonomous SKU is a configuration of the platform the buyer already runs.

Watch

Sierra, Decagon, Parloa: the autonomous-native independents funded at frontier marks (~\$15.8B³⁸, ~\$4.5B⁴⁰, ~\$3B⁴¹) and priced per outcome; whether that capital out-runs the suites' installed-base advantage is the market's central contest. **The whole thesis:** whether rising fulfillment plus public per-

resolution pricing (fact) converts into seat elimination (forecast), or the live counter-signal wins (Pattern Claim 3's mid-2027 checkpoint). **Lorikeet** and the thin Series-A cohort: funding is real and reported as fact, and under the viability discipline the report makes no call on their survival.

Losers

No graded contender in this market carries a public distress or failure signal: the Funding & Fault-Lines section records no distress or viability event on any private. The clearest *restructuring* here is consolidation rather than failure: incumbents buying capability into the owned stack (NICE's ~\$955M Cognigy purchase) rather than any vendor going under. The genuinely exposed position is not a company at all. It is per-seat licensing itself – and the published per-resolution price lists are already displacing it. The live counter-signal to the whole displacement thesis remains the Klarna reversal discussed in Pattern Claim 3.

5.7 The Road Ahead (H2 2026 watchlist)

1. **Per-resolution pricing on flagship SKUs** (Pattern Claim 1's checkpoint), plus the single most important counter-signal: any vendor reverting off per-resolution.
2. **One named engine spanning assist + autonomous** across ≥ 3 Gravity vendors (Pattern Claim 2's checkpoint): the single-engine collapse at the product surface.
3. **Sustained (not pilot) autonomous fulfillment rates** vs Klarna-style reversals (Pattern Claim 3's checkpoint): the displacement falsification.
4. **Autonomous-agent trust/governance/evaluation tooling** becoming the procurement gate (Five9, Genesys, Salesforce, Sprinklr).
5. **The funding frenzy's first correction**: whether the frontier valuations (Sierra/Decagon/Parloa) hold or the Gartner cancellation counter-signal reaches the cap table.

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